

The Complete AI Freelancer Tool Stack

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Every tool I use to run a \$30K+ AI automation business. Organized by category. Free alternatives included.

AI ASSISTANTS — YOUR THINKING PARTNERS

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
ChatGPT	Speed — emails, drafts, brainstorming	Free / \$20/mo Plus	Quick tasks, first drafts, proposals
Claude	Depth — complex projects, planning	Free / \$20-200/mo	System architecture, SOPs, long conversations
Gemini	Research — connected to Google	Free	Client research before calls, industry analysis
Perplexity	Research with sources	Free / \$20/mo	Fact-checking, competitive analysis

AUTOMATION ENGINES — WHERE YOU BUILD CLIENT PROJECTS

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
n8n	Complex automations, self-hosted	Free (open source)	Client projects — no monthly fees for them
Make.com	Visual automation, easy integrations	\$9/mo+	Quick integrations, client-friendly interface
Zapier	Simple 2-step automations	Free (limited) / \$20/mo	Simple connections when Make/n8n is overkill

CLIENT MANAGEMENT — RUN YOUR BUSINESS

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
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Notion	Everything hub — clients, tasks, content	Free	Daily — it runs your entire business
ClickUp	Project management for client work	Free / \$12/mo	Managing multiple client projects
Google Sheets	Quick tracking, client tool lists	Free	Before you need a CRM (under 5 clients)

COMMUNICATION — TALK TO CLIENTS

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
Slack	Real-time client communication	Free	Daily client updates and notifications
Vidyard	Video proposals and walkthroughs	Free	Every proposal — this is the #1 differentiator
Calendly	Auto-schedule calls	Free	Discovery calls, client check-ins
Miro	Visual project planning	Free	Onboarding — show the project flow visually

OUTREACH & LEAD GEN — GET CLIENTS

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
Upwork	Freelance marketplace	Free to join	Primary client acquisition channel
Instantly.ai	Cold email + website visitor tracking	\$30/mo+	Outbound campaigns, warm lead capture
LinkedIn Sales Navigator	Finding decision makers	\$99/mo	Building targeted prospect lists
Apollo.io	Contact data enrichment	Free (limited)	Finding emails and phone numbers

CRM & CLIENT DELIVERY

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
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Go High Level	All-in-one CRM for client projects	\$97/mo+	Building CRMs for clients
Airtable	Flexible database + automation	Free / \$20/mo	Candidate tracking, hiring systems
Supabase	Database for complex projects	Free	When you need SQL power behind automations

DESIGN & CONTENT

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Use When
Canva	Presentations, social graphics	Free	Client deliverables, social content
Loom	Screen recordings for SOPs	Free	Recording processes for SOP generation

HOW TO START (IF YOU HAVE \$0)

Phase 1 (Free): ChatGPT free + n8n + Notion + Canva + Loom + Vidyard + Google Sheets

Phase 2 (After first \$1,000): Add ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro + Calendly + Slack

Phase 3 (After \$3,000/month): Add Make.com + Instantly + premium AI tools

Phase 4 (After \$5,000/month): Add LinkedIn Sales Navigator + Go High Level + Supabase

Don't buy Phase 4 tools when you're at Phase 1. Scale your tools with your revenue.